Writing Assignment 2

Geography 5312

Henry Reissig

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Hurricane Katrina was the costliest and one the deadliest storms to strike the United States and New Orleans took the brunt of its destruction. In the aftermath of Hurricane Katrina though, there is an opportunity for the local, state, and the federal governments to work together in rebuilding the city of New Orleans and help its inhabitants create a community that is robust and vibrant plus help prevent or minimize the damage caused from a future storm. Some of the important themes to keep in mind with planning the reconstruction of the city this paper considers is: (1) prevention of another disaster from happening, (2) plan the rebuilt city in such a way to capture the integrity of its culture and the neighborhoods within it, and (3) find ways of generating revenue to pay for these improvements in such a way that minimizes impact on the residents of the city.

First and foremost, preventing another levee failure to begin with should be the top priority of the Federal Government. Without an improved levee system, the thought that all could be lost again with another hurricane will keep any serious development away. The Army Corps of Engineers or whoever else is qualified need to improve the levee system around the city to take at least a category four hurricane, but preferably a category five if possible. The state and federal government also need to maintain the marsh lands around the city to protect the city and surrounding areas from storm surges with these natural barriers.

The city can help out New Orleans by implementing planned unit developments (PUD) throughout the affected parts of the city to give developers more flexibility in redesigning the the affected neighborhoods. PUD's will allow a variety of development including residential, commercial, retail and industrial to be mixed in areas that otherwise had only one or two of these. Another way the city planners can take into account the potential flood prone areas within the city is to implement a floodplain overlay district that could allow recreational areas, parks, and other open areas that would have less economic impact in case another hurricane or tropical storm hits near the city. On a similar note, the city planners can implement overlay districts to adequately plan areas along Lake Pontchartrain to the north – especially the Ninth Ward that has some of lowest elevations in the city and is particularly vulnerable to levee failure.

The top stakeholders to consider in rebuilding New Orleans are the residents. For those affected by the hurricane, getting them a place to live, work, shop and play will help bring back many of the residents that left to come back and improve the lives of the ones that remain. For every parcel of land that is unoccupied, the community loses not only property tax money, but all the money that comes in with each person moving back. The city, state and federal government need to give incentives for these residents to rebuild either through tax incentives or working with banks to give low interest loans to rebuild. Many people affected by the hurricane did not have property insurance, so much more needs to be done to have insurance companies give discounts to these people with help from the federal government. To help the planning process reflect the culture and values of the city, the residents need to play an integral part of the planning process. This will ensure that that the rebuilt city will reflect the culture

and personal taste of the residents. To do this, the city planners can have town hall meetings and community planning workshops.

Incentives for businesses, especially minority owned businesses, should be given to move back to areas that they were displaced from and possibly locate to areas that have never had a vibrant business community. These incentives can include property tax reductions or tax credits for building in certain targeted areas of the city. Additional tax incentives can be included for meeting renewable building practices and for minority owned businesses. The initial cost for all these incentives should be recovered from the property tax and income tax generated by the increase in number of these businesses and the additional money generated for the business owners. Community based programs should be created to bring the community together to work together for a common cause of rebuilding the city. Extending existing programs such as Habitat for Humanity can bring together those that are able bodied to help rebuild the city.

To generate money to pay for rebuilding New Orleans it is important to harness the money that is already associated with the city and the state of Louisiana. Tax increases are never popular, but revenue can be generated from taxes that are not from the residents and small businesses of the city that are already struggling and directed towards sectors that are more robust and less likely to be affected by tax increases. Tourism is a large money generator for the city of New Orleans and one way to take advantage of the dollars coming is by creating or increasing the taxes associated with tourism and using that money to rebuild the city. These taxes could include hotel, car rental, or an increase in taxing alcohol permits. Another large money

generator for the community is the oil and gas industry and either a higher tax on that industry or a larger allocation of the existing tax can be used to rebuild the city as well. Research would have to be done on how much you can increase with minimal impact on these two sectors, but this is one way to generate more revenue with minimal impact to the citizens or small businesses.

By fixing the problems that caused the flooding to begin with along with incentives and money to rebuild a well planned community , the city of New Orleans can be better off in the future than before Hurrican Katrina.